

Leading the pack: Vikram Partap Singh is the highest Indian goalscorer in the ISL this season, with seven goals.

FSDL/ISL MEDIA

player in the first XI. More often than not, it is the overseas striker. But coaches need to give confidence to Indian strikers. If the coach believes in you, you can invariably do well," Jeje had added.

"Indian strikers have to work harder than other players. If you don't score soon, it might be a problem because you will be compared to a foreign striker. The club has to give more opportunities to Indian strikers ultimately. Maybe, then you will see their performances improve."

Scratching beyond the surface

In the ISL, Indian goalscorers (other than Chhetri) hardly play regularly as a striker. For instance, Vikram Partap Singh, the highest Indian goalscorer in the league this season, with seven goals, has not started as a striker in a single game for Mumbai City FC (MCFC).

In fact, among the league's top 20 goalscorers, according to the ISL website on April 7, there are three

Indians — Vikram, Nandhakumar Sekar and Chhangte — and only one of them has played more than a game as a striker.

"People are always looking at the question that we all know the answer to. Someone will. When the time comes, we need to see who is the most stable player in that position. How many centre-forwards do we have in India? Hardly any," Stimac said during the Asian Cup.

"So, where do you think I'm going to find them from, Croatia? The people need to work on that seriously."

On having a look at the graph, it is evident that teams with no Indians starting as centre-forwards have still found goals from them, with MCFC leading the list.

Though MCFC has three proven Indian goalscorers — Bipin Singh (three goals), Chhangte (five goals) and Vikram (seven goals) — all have spent most of their match-time playing as wide midfielders or wingers.

An important data point for goalscorers would also be the age of Indian and foreign goalscorers. For overseas players, the average age of goalscorers is 31.34 years while that of Indian goalscorers is 25.13 years. This shows that the ISL has youngsters in India who can score but are not often used as centre-forwards.

"We need to allow young boys to start playing as a centre-forward for us, in the lower leagues, then the ISL and hopefully, in foreign clubs someday," Stimac had suggested.

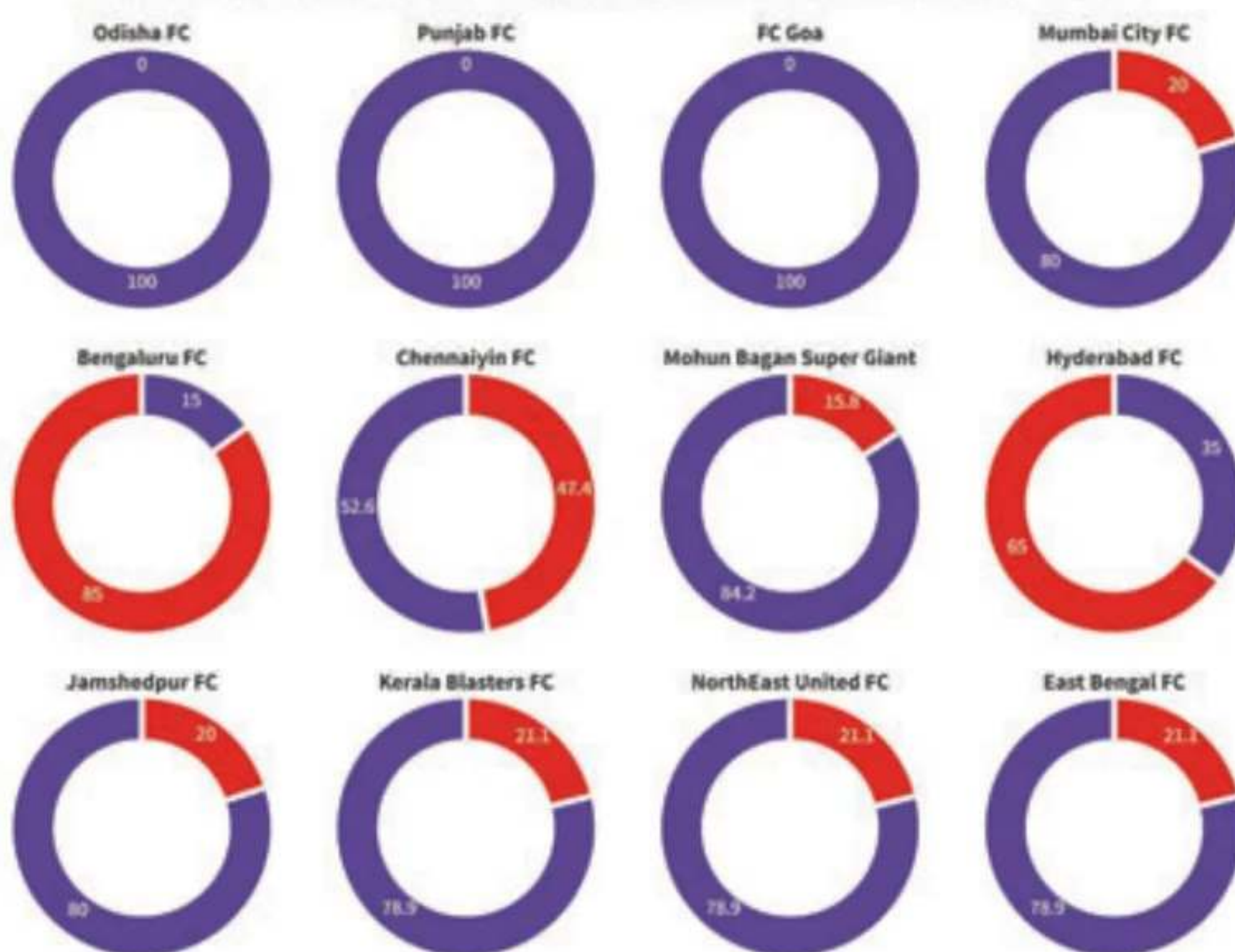
"And then hope that someone like Sunil Chhetri will appear to represent the country. But unless people start working seriously on a long-term plan, nothing will happen."

Stimac has tried to deploy other



Indian Super League clubs playing Indians as strikers in 2023-24 season

■ Percentage of matches with all foreign strikers ■ Percentage of matches with Indians as at least one of the strikers



Source: FBREF, Opta • All data in the article is till the ISL match Odisha FC vs Punjab FC on April 2, 2024